

Chapter 123-2

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When Liang Shi woke up the next day, there was no one home.

Xu Qingzhu had already gone to work.

It was probably her body's compensation mechanism at work—after those few glasses of wine last night, Liang Shi had slept soundly through the night.

She had directly made up for all the sleep she'd lost from staying up late and waking up early during her time with the film crew.

When she woke up, she was in the master bedroom, and she didn't feel too surprised, as if this was her room all along.

But as memories slowly came back together, she first thought of what happened at the bar last night—helplessly embarrassed, she ultimately felt it was too absurd.

Yet Xu Qingzhu had also indulged her in this absurdity.

Liang Shi picked up her phone to check messages. There was only one message sent by Chen Mian at three in the morning: 【I miss Qi Jiao.】

Just five short words, yet they made Liang Shi's mood this morning plummet like a roller coaster.

She replied: 【After this matter is over, let's go visit her grave.】

Qi Jiao's brief life was lived like a soulless shell—surely in death she couldn't still be just a nameless tombstone?

So they needed to help engrave Qi Jiao's own name on her tombstone.

Rather than letting her remain a wandering ghost even in death.¹

Liang Shi lay in bed for a while. When sunlight poured in through the gaps in the curtains, she raised her arm to block the sudden light.

She basked in the sun for a bit before getting up.

She had originally planned to get up and make some breakfast, but found that Xu Qingzhu had already placed the purchased breakfast on the dining table.

Liang Shi had just opened the packaging when the phone rang.

It was a call from the Municipal Public Security Bureau. Gu Xingyue's surgery had gone smoothly, and she had already woken up today.

At the same time, Gu Zhaoyuan had also rushed to the Municipal Public Security Bureau.

As the person who reported the case, Liang Shi needed to cooperate with the police investigation. Yesterday's statement was only a small part; because it involved a murder case from many years ago, Liang Shi still needed to come to the hospital.

This matter had attracted attention from higher-ups. For one, the person involved was considered a prominent entrepreneur in the city; for another, the nature of the case was egregious—it could no longer be classified as a simple family dispute.

The more than twenty stab wounds on Qi Xiangui's body alone were enough to make one's blood run cold.

Liang Shi hurriedly ate a few bites and drove to the hospital.

Chen Mian had probably drunk too much last night; she still hadn't woken up and hadn't replied to Liang Shi's message.

When Liang Shi arrived at the hospital, it happened to be Zhao Xuning's shift, and the two ran right into each other at the entrance.

The moment Zhao Xuning saw her, she adjusted her glasses and looked her up and down, her expression complicated.

Liang Shi immediately said, "I'm here to see someone."

Zhao Xuning made an "oh" sound, her voice as cool and detached as always, "I thought you were here to get an annual membership."

Liang Shi: "....."

Zhao Xuning was wearing a white shirt and black pants with a knee-length coat, her hair casually tied in a low ponytail—not much different from her usual attire.

The two walked side by side. Although Zhao Xuning was about the same height as Liang Shi, Zhao Xuning had developed an extremely fast walking pace from her usual work at the hospital. Liang Shi had to walk briskly to keep up with her rhythm.

The elevator wasn't too crowded at this hour. Liang Shi and Zhao Xuning entered and stood in a corner.

Remembering what happened that day at the film set, Liang Shi glanced sideways at Zhao Xuning again and again.

Zhao Xuning turned her face to look at her, "Something the matter?"

Liang Shi first shook her head, then Zhao Xuning asked, "Who are you here to see?"

"A friend." Liang Shi said, "It's not convenient for you to know."

Zhao Xuning paused for two seconds: "Gu Xingyue?"

Liang Shi: "....."

When she and Chen Mian came yesterday, they hadn't seen Zhao Xuning.

Yet she hadn't expected Zhao Xuning to guess it in one try.

"Her surgery was performed by our department head." Zhao Xuning said, "I assisted."

Even as doctors, they didn't often encounter this type of patient in their daily work—eight wounds on her body in total, each one avoiding vital points, yet each one was a major bleeding site. The slightest carelessness would have meant she couldn't be saved.

At the time, their department head had even guessed while performing the surgery whether this person was a medical student.

Though that was just a joke.

Moreover, Gu Xingyue had one wound on her body that was a fatal injury—that cut landed on her waist, twenty centimeters long, and suturing alone took over three hours.

Because she was designated as a key protected individual by the Municipal Public Security Bureau, they had used the hospital's most prestigious doctors. They hadn't dared to use interns as assistants—the physicians had directly stepped in themselves.

After that surgery was completed, their elderly department head had gone to get a glucose drip.

When Zhao Xuning saw that face, she knew it was Qi Jiao. But unexpectedly, when recording the patient information after the surgery, the name recorded was actually Gu Xingyue.

She wanted to investigate, so she used some connections and asked a relative who worked at the Municipal Bureau. Naturally, she learned some inside information.

At the same time, the Municipal Public Security Bureau had also sent over samples for DNA testing.

Given that Zhao Xuning already knew something about this matter, with all this additional information, what couldn't she deduce?

There were too many people in the elevator, so it wasn't convenient to discuss these things. When getting off the elevator, Zhao Xuning's footsteps paused slightly, and she finally called to Liang Shi: "Come with me."

Footnotes:

¹ **Wandering ghost (孤魂野鬼):** In Chinese folk beliefs, spirits of the dead who have no one to make offerings to them or who are not properly buried become "lonely souls and wild ghosts" (孤魂野鬼), doomed to wander without rest. Having one's name on a tombstone and receiving proper ancestral rites is considered essential for the deceased's peace in the afterlife.